

Complete Calisthenics Program

Lower Body · Core · Upper Body

4–5 days per week · ~45 minutes per session

Low-impact ankle protocol · Calf/foot development priority

Program Overview

4 training days per week plus an optional active mobility day. Lower body and core are the primary focus; upper body is integrated as a daily finisher so sessions stay near 45 minutes. Similar muscle groups do not stack on consecutive days.

Equipment

- Pull-up / dip bar
- Roman chair
- Nordic curl tool
- Kettlebell and/or sandbag
- Resistance bands (various strengths)
- Ab roller

Weekly Schedule

Day	When	Lower / core focus	Upper / extras
Day 1	Mon	Quad + anterior core	Pull-ups · dips (pull emphasis)
Day 2	Tue	Posterior chain + hip flexors + spinal core	Pull-ups · push-ups (balanced)
Day 3	Thu	Calf / foot + abductors + adductors	None (optional: 2 sets push-ups)
Day 4	Fri	Full lower integration + rotational core	Push-ups · dips · pull-ups (push emphasis) + calf finisher
Day 5	Any rest day	Active mobility (optional)	—

Suggested split: Mon / Tue / Thu / Fri. Day 5 mobility on any rest day. Do not train the same primary muscle group on consecutive days.

Ankle Protocol

All exercises are bilateral and low-impact. No single-leg calf work or plyometrics until cleared. Tibialis raises and foot doming are rehabilitative — treat them as precise, slow, and non-negotiable. Reassess restrictions every 4–6 weeks.

Upper Body Logic

Pull-ups are pulling; dips and push-ups are pushing and compete for recovery. The program targets roughly equal push and pull sets per week (≈9 each) to protect shoulder health. See each day for the specific distribution.

Progression Rules

- Add load (kettlebell, sandbag, heavier band) or +2 reps when all sets feel consistently easy with good form.
- Timed holds: add 10 seconds when you hit the top of the prescribed range.
- Nordic negatives: make the lower slower (aim for 8 sec) before attempting concentric work.
- Calf raises: full range of motion always. A full-range bodyweight rep beats a partial-range loaded rep.
- Upper body: once any set consistently exceeds 15 reps, add a weighted vest, sandbag, or kettlebell.

Ankle milestones — Stage 2 (single-leg cleared): progress to single-leg calf raises, remove bilateral-only restriction. Stage 3 (plyometrics cleared): add jump rope, pogo hops, bilateral jump squats.

Morning Routine — Jump Rope + Horse Stance

Daily or 5–6× per week · ~15–20 min · Do this as a standalone morning practice, separate from the main training session.

Jump rope phases are gated by your ankle clearance. Phase 1 is available now — soft bilateral bouncing is actually therapeutic, providing low-level tendon loading that supports Achilles adaptation. Do not skip ahead to Phase 2 or 3 until single-leg and plyometric work are medically cleared.

ACTIVATION · 2 MIN

Ankle circles 10 each direction · Hip circles 10 each direction · Wrist + shoulder rolls · 20 light marches in place

JUMP ROPE — CURRENT PROTOCOL (PHASE 1 · ANKLE RESTRICTED)

Round	Duration	Cue
Round 1	2 min easy	Both feet, minimal height off the floor. Land softly through the ball of the foot — never flat-footed or heel-first. Slow, rhythmic pace. Stop if ankle feels unstable.
Rest	60s	Shake out the calves. Gentle ankle circles if needed.
Round 2	2 min	Same pace. Focus on a consistent rhythm and quiet landings rather than speed. This is tendon conditioning, not cardio.
Rest	60s	
Round 3	2 min	Same. If the ankles feel solid and confident, allow a very slight increase in pace in the final 30 seconds.

JUMP ROPE — PROGRESSION PHASES (UNLOCK WHEN ANKLE CLEARED)

Phase	Cleared when	Protocol change
Phase 2 — alternating feet	Single-leg work cleared	Switch between two-foot bounce and alternating-foot run. Add a 4th round. Begin building pace. Introduce short 15-sec faster intervals within rounds.
Phase 3 — full intensity	Plyometrics cleared	Full-speed rounds, footwork drills (boxer skip, high knees, lateral shifts), double-under attempts. Extend to 4–5 rounds of 2–3 min. Introduce single-leg bounce carefully.

HORSE STANCE (MA BU) — HOLDS

Stage	Hold	Cues and depth
Week 1–2	3 × 30s	Feet 2× shoulder width, toes slightly out. Thighs at roughly 45° to the floor — this is higher than classical horse stance. Back straight, chest up, hands on hips or in guard.
Week 3–4	3 × 45s	Begin sinking lower — aim for thighs between 45° and parallel. Knees track over the second toe. Do not let the knees cave inward.
Week 5–8	3 × 60–90s	Thighs approaching parallel to the floor. This is the classical depth. The quads and adductors will burn significantly — stay with it through the discomfort.
Advanced	3 × 90s+	Deepen below parallel if mobility allows. Add arm work: guard position, slow punches, or hold a light kettlebell at chest. Extend holds to 2–3 min over months.

Rest 30–45s between horse stance sets. Breathe slowly and deliberately during the hold — inhale 4 counts, exhale 4 counts. The mental component is part of the practice: the discomfort is the point. Horse stance builds isometric quad, glute, adductor, and hip flexor strength that directly transfers to squatting depth and stability.

COOL-DOWN · 2 MIN

Standing calf stretch 30s/side · Standing quad stretch 30s/side · Shake out the legs

Day 1 — Quad Dominant + Anterior Core

Equipment: kettlebell, resistance band, pull-up bar · Suggested: Monday

WARM-UP · 5 MIN

Seated ankle circles 2×10 each direction · Hip circles · Leg swings 10 each · Banded clamshell activation 1×15/side

QUAD BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Spanish squat	3 × 10–12	Quads, knee	Band around post at knee height. Deep squat, 3-sec pause at bottom.
Goblet squat	3 × 10	Quads, adductors	Kettlebell at chest, knees out. 2-sec pause at bottom, parallel or below.
Wall sit	3 × 45s	Quads (isometric)	Thighs parallel to floor, back flat. 60s rest between sets.
Reverse lunge	3 × 10/side	Quads, hip flexors	Step back — easier on ankles. Drive through the front heel to stand.
Sissy squat	3 × 8	Quads, knee mob.	Hold band/post for balance. Knees forward, body straight, rise onto toes.

CORE BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Dead bug	3 × 8/side	Abs, transverse	Opposite arm + leg lower. Press lower back into the floor throughout.
Ab roller	3 × 8	Full anterior core	Roll out only to neutral spine. Pull back by drawing abs in, not hinging.
Hanging knee raise	3 × 10–12	Lower abs, hip flexors	Dead hang, draw knees to chest. 2–3 sec lower. No swinging.

UPPER BODY — PULL EMPHASIS

Exercise	Volume	Cue
Pull-ups	4 × max (–1–2)	Dead hang → chin over bar. Stop 1–2 reps before failure. Use band assist if max < 5.
Dips	2 × max (–1–2)	Slight forward lean for chest. Lock out at top. Stop if shoulder is painful (not just burning).

MOBILITY FINISHER · 5 MIN

Couch stretch 2×60s/side (quad + hip flexor) · 90/90 hip switch 2×60s/side

Day 2 — Posterior Chain + Hip Flexors + Spinal Core

Equipment: Nordic curl tool, kettlebell, Roman chair, band · Suggested: Tuesday

WARM-UP · 5 MIN

Cat/cow 10 reps · Hip hinge practice against wall · Banded good morning 2×10 · World's greatest stretch 3/side

HAMSTRING BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Nordic curl negative	3 × 5 (5-sec lower)	Hamstrings	Lower as slowly as possible. Push up with hands. Most effective hamstring exercise available.
Kettlebell RDL	3 × 10	Hamstrings, lower back	Push hips back until strong stretch. Spine neutral throughout, do not let lower back round.
Glute bridge (weighted)	3 × 15	Hamstrings, glutes	Sandbag or kettlebell across hips. Squeeze glutes at top for 1–2s, drive through heels.
Good morning	3 × 12	Hamstrings, erectors	Hands behind head, hinge to near-parallel. Builds hinge pattern and hamstring length.

HIP FLEXOR BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Psoas march (banded)	3 × 10/side	Hip flexors, core	Band at foot, anchored low. Drive knee to chest. Pelvis stable — do not hike the hip.
Standing band hip flexion	3 × 12/side	Iliopsoas	Band at ankle, anchored behind. Drive leg forward and up. Stay tall — no backward lean.

SPINAL CORE BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Roman chair back extension	3 × 12	Spinal erectors, glutes	Start rounded, extend to neutral (not hyperextended). 1-sec pause at top.
Roman chair oblique raise	3 × 10/side	Obliques, QL	Body faces sideways. Lower laterally, raise to horizontal. Targets the lateral chain.
Bird dog	3 × 8/side	Erectors, core stability	Opposite arm + leg. Hold 2s at top. Lumbar must not rotate or dip.

UPPER BODY — PULL + PUSH

Exercise	Volume	Cue
Pull-ups	3 × max (–1–2)	Same cues as Day 1. Dead hang bottom, chin over bar top.
Push-ups	3 × max (–1–2)	Hands slightly wider than shoulders, elbows ~45°. Chest to floor. Rigid body throughout.

MOBILITY FINISHER · 5 MIN

Figure-4 / pigeon stretch 2×60s/side (piriformis + rotators) · Standing hip flexor stretch 2×60s/side

Day 3 — Calf / Foot Complex + Abductors + Adductors

Equipment: resistance band, chair or step for seated raises · Suggested: Thursday

Most critical day for ankle rehab. All calf work is slow and precise — this is not a conditioning block. No upper body today.

WARM-UP · 5 MIN

Seated ankle alphabet (draw A–Z each foot) · Toe spreads + curls 2×10 · Foot rolling on ball 60s/foot

CALF / FOOT BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Seated calf raise	4 × 15–20	Soleus (deep calf)	90° knee angle isolates the soleus. Full range. 3-sec lower. Add thigh load if available.
Standing bilateral calf raise	4 × 15 (3-3)	Gastrocnemius	3 sec up, pause, 3 sec down. On a step edge if possible for full stretch at bottom.
Eccentric bilateral calf lower	3 × 10 (5-sec)	Achilles / tendons	Rise on both feet, lower as slowly as possible. Eccentric load drives tendon adaptation.
Tibialis anterior raise	3 × 20	Tibialis anterior	Seated, lift forefoot as high as possible, hold 1s, lower slowly. Critical for ankle stability.
Foot doming / short foot	3 × 10 (3s hold)	Foot intrinsics, arch	Pull ball of foot toward heel without curling toes. Activates arch muscles most people neglect.
Toe spread + curl	2 × 15	Foot intrinsics	Spread toes wide (5s), then curl under (5s). Builds intrinsic motor control.

ABDUCTOR BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Clamshell (banded)	3 × 15/side	Glute medius	Band above knees. Hips at 45°. Rotate top knee up without rolling the pelvis back.
Standing band abduction	3 × 15/side	Glute medius, TFL	Band at ankle, anchored opposite side. Sweep leg out, keep pelvis level.

ADDUCTOR BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Copenhagen plank (kneeling)	3 × 20s/side	Adductors	Top knee on bench. Side plank held by the top adductor. Progress to full leg over time.
Banded adductor squeeze	3 × 15	Adductors	Band around both knees. Squeeze against resistance. Good complement to Copenhagen.

MOBILITY FINISHER · 5 MIN

Gastroc stretch (straight leg) 2×60s/side · Soleus stretch (bent knee) 2×60s/side · Sumo squat hold 2×45s, elbows pushing knees out

Day 4 — Full Lower Integration + Rotational Core

Equipment: kettlebell, Nordic curl tool, Roman chair, band, pull-up bar · Suggested: Friday

Integration and heaviest loading day. Go heavier on the goblet squat than Day 1. Challenge the Nordic curl concentric.

COMPOUND LOWER BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Goblet squat (heavy)	4 × 10	Quads, adductors, glutes	Heavier than Day 1. 3-sec descent, 1–2s pause. Drive floor away.
Kettlebell sumo deadlift	3 × 10	Hamstrings, adductors	Wide stance, toes out 45°. Targets inner hamstrings and adductors.
Reverse lunge (loaded)	3 × 10/side	Quads, hip flexors	Kettlebell ipsilateral hand for anti-lateral challenge, or both hands loaded.
Nordic curl (working)	3 × 5–8	Hamstrings	Attempt partial concentric pull. Hands only for final inches. Strength builds slowly.

CORE BLOCK

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Plank	3 × 45–60s	Full core	RKC: drive elbows toward toes. Squeeze glutes and quads. Straight line head to heel.
Side plank	3 × 35–45s/side	Obliques, QL	Top hip must not sag. Progress by adding hip dips.
Pallof press (banded)	3 × 10/side	Anti-rotation core	Band at chest height. Press out, hold 2s, return. Resist the rotation throughout.
Roman chair extension (wtd)	3 × 10	Spinal erectors	Kettlebell at chest or behind head. Neutral at top — do not hyperextend.
Ab roller	3 × 8–10	Full anterior core	Slightly more volume than Day 1. Full control, no hip dipping.

UPPER BODY — PUSH EMPHASIS

Exercise	Volume	Cue
Push-ups	4 × max (–1–2)	Feet elevated once flat >15 reps. Elbows 45°, chest to floor, rigid body.
Dips	3 × max (–1–2)	Full lock-out at top. Add sandbag on lap when max consistently >15 reps.
Pull-ups	2 × max (–1–2)	Lower pull volume to balance push-heavy day. Full range, controlled descent.

CALF FINISHER · 10 MIN (2ND WEEKLY EXPOSURE)

Exercise	Volume	Muscles	Key cue
Standing bilateral calf raise	3 × 15 (3-3)	Gastrocnemius	Same slow tempo as Day 3. Second weekly calf exposure drives growth beyond maintenance.
Seated calf raise	3 × 15	Soleus	Full range, add thigh load if available.
Tibialis anterior raise	2 × 20	Tibialis anterior	Keep in every session during ankle rehab. Slow and deliberate.

MOBILITY FINISHER · 5 MIN

Lying spinal rotation 2×60s/side · Deep squat hold 2×45s, heels flat (use band counterbalance if needed)

Day 5 — Active Mobility (Optional)

Duration: 30–40 min · No load · Any rest day

No soreness should come from this day. If any position is painful rather than uncomfortable, back off. Breathe into the stretch — do not force range.

HIP MOBILITY FLOW · 10 MIN

Hip circles 10 each direction · 90/90 transitions 5 each side · Pigeon pose 90s/side · Lateral lunge to adductor stretch 60s/side

ANKLE + FOOT FLOW · 10 MIN

Ankle circles both directions each foot · Toe mobility: spread, curl, individual toe lifts · Towel toe scrunches 2×15 · Heel-to-toe weight shifts 10 slow reps

SPINAL + THORACIC FLOW · 10 MIN

Cat/cow 10 reps · Seated thoracic rotation 10/side · Seated spinal twist hold 60s/side · World's greatest stretch 5/side (slow)

POSTERIOR CHAIN STRETCH · 10 MIN

Standing hamstring PNF stretch — contract 5s, relax, deepen — 3 rounds each side · Calf stretch bent + straight knee 60s each · Supine butterfly (adductor) 2 min hold

12-Week Progression — Overview

The program runs in three phases of four weeks each. Each phase shifts the primary training stimulus. Read this page first, then refer to the per-day and morning-routine progression tables that follow.

Weeks	Phase	Primary stimulus	How to train
1–4	Foundation	Movement quality, pattern grooming	Focus on form before load. Stop 2 reps short of failure on every set. Rest 90–120s. If anything hurts (not burns), drop reps.
5–8	Development	Volume accumulation, first load increases	Add weight or reps to key exercises. Stop 1 rep short of failure. Rest 75–90s. Push tempo on calf and core work.
9–12	Strength	Intensity, harder variations, max effort	Heavier loads, harder progressions, shorter rest (60–75s). True max effort on upper body sets. Full Nordic curl concentric attempts.

WEEKLY CALENDAR

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Notes
Wk 1	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Foundation — learn all patterns
Wk 2	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Foundation — build rhythm and consistency
Wk 3	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Foundation — increase reps toward top of range
Wk 4	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Foundation — deload if fatigued (drop 1 set/day)
Wk 5	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Development — first load increases on key exercises
Wk 6	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Development — push volume
Wk 7	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Development — full prescribed volume at new loads
Wk 8	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Development — deload if fatigued (drop 1 set/day)
Wk 9	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Strength — harder variations, shorter rest
Wk 10	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Strength — push for new maxes on upper body
Wk 11	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Strength — full intensity across all days
Wk 12	Day 1	Day 2	Rest	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5*	Strength — test week: max reps on 1 set per exercise

* Day 5 is optional. Morning routine runs daily (or 5–6×/week) independently of this schedule. Deload weeks: keep all exercises, drop 1 set per block, reduce load by ~10%.

12-Week Progression — Days 1 & 2

Each cell shows the prescription change for that phase. Exercises not listed hold the base prescription from the day page and progress by feel within phase rules.

Exercise	Phase 1 · W1–4	Phase 2 · W5–8	Phase 3 · W9–12
Day 1 — Quad Dominant + Anterior Core			
Spanish squat	3×10, 3-1-1 tempo	3×12, 3-2-1, more band tension	4×10, 3-3-1, heaviest available band
Goblet squat	3×10, light KB	3×10, heavier KB, 2s pause	4×8, heavy KB, 3s pause
Wall sit	3×45s	3×60s	3×75s or add light KB at chest
Reverse lunge	3×8/side, bodyweight	3×10/side, light KB	3×12/side, loaded KB
Sissy squat	3×6, band assist	3×8, minimal band assist	3×10, unassisted
Dead bug	3×8/side	3×10/side	3×12/side, legs fully extended
Ab roller	3×6, short range	3×8, mid range	3×10, full extension
Hanging knee raise	3×8, knees bent	3×12, knees bent	3×10, legs straight (leg raise)
Pull-ups	4×max, band if needed	4×max, reduce band	4×max, add KB if >10 clean reps
Dips	2×max	3×max	3×max, add weight if >12
Day 2 — Posterior Chain + Hip Flexors + Spinal Core			
Nordic curl negative	3×4, 5s lower	3×5, 6s lower	3×5–6, attempt partial concentric
Kettlebell RDL	3×10, light KB	3×10, heavier KB	4×10, heaviest KB available
Glute bridge (wtd)	3×12, bodyweight	3×15, sandbag on hips	3×15, heavier load or single-leg†
Good morning	3×10	3×12	3×12, add light band resistance
Roman chair ext.	3×10, bodyweight	3×12, bodyweight	3×12, light KB hold at chest
Roman chair oblique	3×8/side	3×10/side	3×12/side
Bird dog	3×6/side, 2s hold	3×8/side, 3s hold	3×10/side, add ankle band
Psoas march	3×10/side, light band	3×12/side, same band	3×12/side, heavier band
Standing hip flexion	3×10/side	3×12/side	3×15/side, heavier band
Pull-ups	3×max, band if needed	3×max, less band	3×max, add KB if >10 clean
Push-ups	3×max, flat	3×max, flat or slow 3s descent	3×max, 4s descent or feet elevated

† Single-leg glute bridge: only unlock when ankle single-leg clearance is confirmed. Until then, load the bilateral version heavier.

12-Week Progression — Days 3 & 4

Calf/foot progression is gradual by design — connective tissue adapts more slowly than muscle. Do not rush the load increases.

Exercise	Phase 1 · W1–4	Phase 2 · W5–8	Phase 3 · W9–12
Day 3 — Calf / Foot Complex + Abductors + Adductors			
Seated calf raise	4×15, bodyweight	4×18, add thigh load	4×20, heavier thigh load
Standing bilateral raise	4×12, 3-3 tempo	4×15, 3-3 tempo	4×15, 4-4 tempo, step edge
Eccentric calf lower	3×8, 5s lower	3×10, 6s lower	3×10, 7–8s lower
Tibialis raise	3×15	3×20	3×20, light band at foot
Foot doming	3×8, seated, 3s hold	3×10, seated, 3s hold	3×12, attempt standing
Toe spread + curl	2×12	2×15	3×15
Clamshell (banded)	3×12/side, light band	3×15/side, same band	3×15/side, heavier band
Standing abduction	3×12/side	3×15/side	3×15/side, heavier band
Copenhagen plank	3×15s, kneeling version	3×20s, kneeling	3×30s or progress to full leg
Adductor squeeze	3×12, light band	3×15, same band	3×15, heavier band
Day 4 — Full Lower Integration + Rotational Core			
Goblet squat (heavy)	4×8	4×10, heavier KB	4×10, heaviest KB + 3s pause
Sumo deadlift	3×8, moderate KB	3×10, heavy KB	4×10, heaviest KB
Reverse lunge (loaded)	3×8/side, light KB	3×10/side, heavier KB	3×12/side, heavy KB
Nordic curl (working)	3×4–5, partial ROM	3×5–6, deeper ROM	3×6–8, full concentric effort
Plank	3×40s	3×50s	3×60s or RKC plank 3×35s
Side plank	3×30s/side	3×40s/side	3×45s/side + hip dips
Pallof press	3×8/side, light band	3×10/side	3×12/side, heavier band
Roman chair ext. (wtd)	3×8, bodyweight	3×10, light KB	3×12, heavy KB
Ab roller	3×6, short range	3×8–10, mid range	3×10–12, full extension
Push-ups	4×max, flat	4×max, try feet elevated	4×max elevated or add weight
Dips	3×max	3×max	3×max, add weight if >12
Pull-ups	2×max	2×max	2×max, add weight if >10
Calf finisher	3×12 each, 3-3 tempo	3×15 each, 3-3 tempo	Same as Day 3 Phase 3

Day 4 is the most demanding day of the week. If you arrive fatigued from Days 1–3, drop 1 set from the compound block rather than grinding through with compromised form.

12-Week Progression — Morning Routine

The morning routine progresses independently of the main program phases. Jump rope phase unlocks are gated by ankle clearance, not weeks on the calendar.

JUMP ROPE PROGRESSION

Weeks	Rounds × Duration	Rest	Focus / notes
1–2	3 × 2 min	75s	Both feet only, minimal height, very slow rhythm. Land softly through the ball of the foot. Stop immediately if ankle feels unstable.
3–4	3 × 2 min	60s	Build a consistent, metronomic rhythm. Quiet landings — the sound of your rope landing should be louder than your feet.
5–6	4 × 2 min	60s	Add a 4th round. This is the first significant volume increase. Keep pace steady — do not speed up.
7–8	4 × 2.5 min	50s	Extend round duration. If ankles are improving, begin attempting very brief alternating-foot intervals within a round (10 sec on, rest of round two-foot).
9–10	4 × 3 min	45s	Full 3-min rounds. If Phase 2 unlocked (single-leg cleared): switch to alternating feet for full rounds + add 15-sec fast intervals.
11–12	5 × 2.5 min	40s	5-round protocol. If Phase 3 unlocked (plyometrics cleared): introduce double-under attempts, high knees, and lateral shifts.

HORSE STANCE PROGRESSION

Weeks	Sets × Hold	Depth	Cues and loading
1–2	3 × 30s	High (~45° thighs)	Feet 2× shoulder width. Arms on hips or guard. Learn the position — discomfort is expected, pain is not.
3–4	3 × 40s	Mid (~35° thighs)	Begin sinking lower each session. Knees track over second toe. Breathe: 4 counts in, 4 counts out.
5–6	3 × 50s	Mid-low (~25° thighs)	The quads and adductors burn significantly here — stay with it. Rest 45s between sets.
7–8	3 × 60s	Low (~15° thighs)	Approaching classical parallel depth. If form breaks (knees caving, torso folding), rise slightly and hold. Rest 40s.
9–10	3 × 75s	Parallel or close	Add arm work: guard position or slow straight punches during hold. This adds shoulder endurance and mental challenge.
11–12	3 × 90s	Parallel or below	Hold a light kettlebell at chest during the stance. Extend toward 2 min over time. Rest 35–40s between sets.

COMBINED MORNING SESSION — WEEK-BY-WEEK DURATION

Weeks	Activation	Jump rope	Horse stance	Total session time
1–2	2 min	~9 min (3 rds)	~3.5 min	~15 min
3–4	2 min	~9 min (3 rds)	~4.5 min	~16 min
5–6	2 min	~11 min (4 rds)	~5.5 min	~19 min
7–8	2 min	~13 min (4 rds)	~6 min	~21 min
9–10	2 min	~16 min (4 rds)	~7 min	~25 min
11–12	2 min	~17 min (5 rds)	~8 min	~27 min

Cool-down (2 min) is included in session time but not shown above: standing calf stretch 30s/side, standing quad stretch 30s/side, shake out the legs.

Reference — Calf Frequency & Upper Body Notes

Why calves need 2–3 sessions per week

Calves are slow-twitch dominant, recover quickly, and are under constant low-level load from daily walking — all of which raise the stimulus threshold for growth. Once-a-week training maintains what you have but rarely produces meaningful hypertrophy in an underdeveloped muscle. This program delivers two dedicated exposures per week (Day 3 full block + Day 4 finisher) with the option of a light third on Day 1.

Range of motion is more important than load. A full-range bodyweight rep with heel below the ball of the foot on a step edge is more hypertrophic than a heavy partial rep. Prioritize ROM before adding weight.

Upper body push / pull distribution

Day	Pull sets	Push sets	Exercises
Day 1	4 (pull-ups)	2 (dips)	Pull-ups 4×max · Dips 2×max
Day 2	3 (pull-ups)	3 (push-ups)	Pull-ups 3×max · Push-ups 3×max
Day 3	—	—	None (optional: 2 sets push-ups)
Day 4	2 (pull-ups)	7 (push-ups + dips)	Push-ups 4×max · Dips 3×max · Pull-ups 2×max
Total/wk	9 pull sets	9 push sets	Balanced horizontal push/pull volume

Exercise technique notes

Pull-ups: Begin from a full dead hang. Pull until chin clears the bar. Stop 1–2 reps before true failure. If max is below 5 reps, use a band for assistance or substitute inverted rows.

Dips: Slight forward lean targets the chest; upright targets the triceps. Lock out fully at the top. If the anterior shoulder is painful (not just burning), stop immediately.

Push-ups: Hands just outside shoulder width, elbows ~45°, chest to floor. Keep the same rigidity as a plank — no sagging hips. Elevate feet or add a slow (4-sec) descent to progress.

Signs to back off

- Joint pain (sharp, localized) vs. muscle fatigue (diffuse, burning) — the former always means stop.
- Soreness persisting beyond 48 hours — reduce volume on the affected day.
- Disrupted sleep or appetite suggesting systemic fatigue — take an extra rest day.